

Benchmark Personal Philosophy of Leadership and Advocacy

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Personal Philosophy of Leadership and Advocacy

I have experienced good leadership in my life, and I have experienced “bad” leadership in my life. I have been a good leader, and I have been a “bad” leader. As I reflect on leadership, the definition of leadership, leadership models, theories of leadership, and personalities of leaders, one thing stands out: I no longer want to use leadership (and thereby people) to gain what I want in this life.

This assignment and the multiple exercises of processing a philosophy of leadership bring to memory a regret in my leadership history with a youth pastor who worked for the church I pastored in Colorado. It was my first senior pastorate and my first staff leadership experience. I was young and green and selfish. I expected behavior and maturity from this youth pastor and his wife that I did not possess myself. In anger, I gave him an ultimatum, and he chose to leave the staff. I do not regret holding him accountable, but I regret the manner in which I held him accountable. That experience taught me that leadership is not about getting what I want or growing a church or counseling practice. Leadership is about working together, differing personalities, ideas of vision, motivation for the work, and past experiences to achieve a common goal. What follows is my understanding of how to do that in the future. I will start by exploring my beliefs about leadership more fully.

Beliefs

Leadership and advocacy for me are about a selfless future facing Christian love. Those who apply for and participate in a graduate-level counseling program are doing so because they want to help others become healthy. It is not my job to train or motivate that out of them. My responsibility is to join them in that desire, kindle the fire, and give them the parameters and skills to do that more effectively. Because of my experience in graduate-level academia, I believe

most people come to a program with a huge passion and limited direction. My professors in my Master's program taught me that a leader can fan the flames of one's God-given passion and ability, or a leader can snuff out that flame in a few words or actions. The story in my introduction has also taught me that a few kind words and compassionate questions can lead a person from misguided ardor to purposeful zeal. I had professors in my Master's program who tried to cut my legs out from under me in an attempt to reshape me. That style of leadership was not for me, and it hurt me. What I need, and I believe many people need, is a ladder to climb to see further into the future. If you can help me see how my misguided, unskilled enthusiasm will play out in the future, I will desire to know how to behave differently. If I can help students, educators, counselors, future counselors, and clients see over that wall of ignorance (and if I can see that wall of ignorance for what it is and not blame people for ignorance), then I believe I can shape people and lead people more like Jesus did. Speaking of Jesus, I can't be him, but I have learned from studying his leadership style. He wasn't afraid of the truth or using shock and awe (which may have been my past leaders' motive for cutting legs out from under people), but he did so in love and kindness. He met people where they were. In John's Gospel, we see the story of the woman at the well, the story of the woman caught in adultery, and in Luke's Gospel, the story of the woman with the issue of blood. Jesus calls one out, tells the other there is another way to find peace, and calls the other daughter. Not to mention the paralytic at the pool of Bethesda who is challenged as a man... "Do you want to get better and stop making excuses or not?" Jesus' leadership style tells me what Lewis points out on page 39 of his chapter on leadership (2022, Chapter 2): there is no one perfect leadership theory or style for every situation.

In addition to this wisdom, my philosophy of leadership and advocacy aligns mainly with a few theories from our text. First, as alluded to above, counselors and counselor educators chose this field out of a desire to help (Lewis, 2022, Chapter 2, p. 37). Keeping that in mind, my philosophy fits best with purposeful, productive leadership models and causes. As described by Lewis (2022, Chapter 2, p. 32), transformational leadership does not necessarily fit with my personality or temperament (I am not charismatic), but it fits with my desire to help. I do not want people to feel they are transactions or check boxes on my journey to somewhere better. I want them to sense that, as stated above, we are on the same road together. This whole idea has me wondering if Greenleaf's servant leader model (Lewis, 2022, Chapter 2, pp. 37-38) best defines what we do as Christian leaders and counselors or if leadership servanthood is the better way to describe the model. Changing servant from the determiner (qualifying what kind of leader I am) to the noun (stating that I am qualifying what kind of servant I am) interests me. However, either way, the phrase holds essential qualifications for my desire to put others first in my leadership and not use them to gain position or power.

Furthermore, understanding that the theories and models of leadership and advocacy I prefer are relational-focused and flexible (Lewis, 2022, Chapter 2, p. 39) is helpful for my philosophy. Possibly the most salient moment I had reading about theories came from reading Casey Minton's story. In Chapter 4 of our text, she describes leadership as a verb vs leadership as a noun (Chang & Minton, 2022, Chapter 4, p. 64). This struck a nerve with me and helped me make sense of some of my past hurtful experiences with leaders. When leaders are only a noun (out front, positionally focused, and directive), I withdraw and put up walls. Those types of leaders seem as though they will only use me and others for their agenda. I prefer to think of leadership as a verb, as in serving others. However, leadership is a verb that necessitates

leadership as a noun on occasion (my wife challenged me on this). So, I need to remember that blending the two is possible and purposeful. Leading takes action, but people need a leader. When this leader is visionary, authentic, and selfless, people follow. That's the kind of leader I want to be.

Vision

Speaking of vision, I hope the future holds many and various opportunities to lead, speak on behalf of, and influence others. My joy would be to stay relational and impact others through my willingness to join them in their education, leadership, advocacy, and life. I see myself deisciplining and mentoring students as I have done many times through counseling and shepherding. I know that being present and safe for others has helped them see that life is hard, but they can make it through with God and others. I believe I have advocated for and encouraged the faculty in the programs I have learned in by lovingly showing them how they impact me. I'm confident that colleagues, department heads, and students will be able to sense my love for them as I seek connection and desire the best for them. All these take is slowing down long enough to see where they are and disciplining myself to hand them a ladder rather than taking their legs.

References

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